

London shows

HAVING GROWN UP in sleepy Stratford, William Shakespeare must have found London an exciting place to live. It was the largest city in northern Europe, and 10 times the size of any other English town. Even before the playhouses were built, London had many different entertainments to offer its citizens. Londoners enjoyed watching cruel bloodsports, such as fights between bulls, bears, and packs of dogs, and they often gathered to watch executions. Many people passed their time by gambling or playing sports, such as lawn bowling.

ENTERTAINMENT CENTER

This map of London dates from 1572, just before the first playhouses were built. At this time, the only buildings specifically intended for entertainment were cockfighting pits, and bull and bear baiting houses, such as the Bear Garden.



Londoners gather to watch an execution

GORY GALLOWS

Londoners were used to the sight of blood, and watching executions for entertainment was a long-standing tradition. The executions of traitors were the most gruesome shows. The traitors were dragged to the gallows behind a horse. They were half-hanged, then brought down alive, so that their bellies could be cut open and their inner organs burned in front of them.

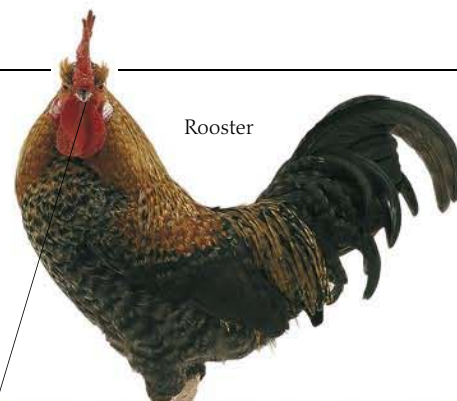


Wooden gallows

Gallows were often specially built for each execution

FIGHTING CHANCE

Setting a pair of roosters to fight each other was a popular 17th-century sport all over Britain. In London alone, there were several cockpits – small, round buildings – where a crowd could watch the birds fight to the death. Onlookers would bet on the outcome of these cockfights.

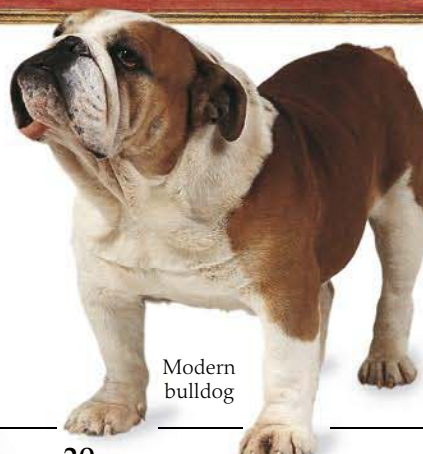


Rooster

Rooster fought with their beaks and spurred feet



Site of the Swan (built between 1595 and 1596)



Modern bulldog

BORN TO BITE

At Bankside, Londoners could see bull baiting with bulldogs that had been specially bred and trained for the sport. The bulldogs, which were much larger than modern bulldogs, were trained to leap at the bull's face. They hung on to its nose or ears, while the angry bull did its best to shake it off.